

Cox and Kings, the oldest travel house in the world, gives out newsletters informing you about their special offers. The site specialises in planned tours in almost all parts of the world, and special tours within the subcontinent. Details of this can be found on www.bharat-dekho.com. If you like to travel at your own pace, you can contact a consultant from the firm who will plan the trip down to the last detail—down to the make of the car you would like to ferry you to your hotel. With its élan, this site is more suited to corporate tours for visiting dignitaries.

A more humble holiday assembler is Erco travels at www.touropersators-india.com. This site focuses on tours in and around India, and offers up to 70 per cent discount. It has a variety of tours classified by adventure, religious, nature, cultural and Ayurveda spas. You can even customise each tour to your preference. The site also lists five and three star hotels in all of the major cities, and spas and resorts, in case you want to venture out on your own.

KVT Holidays (www.kvtholidays.com) and Raj Travels (www.raj-travels.com) is another place to look out for more options on package deals. KVT focuses

exclusively on a variety of tours in India, giving one all the ingredients an exciting holiday should be made up of—leisure beaches, natural wildlife, domestic packages and healthy servings of culture. It also has the rather unusual adventure tours that include mountaineering, trekking, hiking, rafting, jeep and biking trips. It zeroes in on the places to ski, white river raft and take jeep and camel safari tours in.

Raj Travels takes you to the tried and tested holiday spots of Europe, Mauritius and the Far East. It regularly features special deals at discounted rates. So this is one site that would pay to keep track of. On the same beat is the Outlook Traveller (www.outlooktraveller.com), an online companion of the print magazine. The site is a dealmine with various discount offers running at almost any given point of time. It brings to your notice the best times to visit any destination with regards to the local festivals and seasons. A quick access to all the airfares to major destinations abroad makes it easy to glimpse through. Most destinations entice you with the writings and experiences of former travellers. The site also gives you current news relating to travel, such the introduction and cancellation of flights or trains.

Will we plan our trips online?

Even with this wealth of services, tales of misuse of credit card details haunt surfers. Web sites have not yet been able to generate trust. Moreover, in the Indian scenario, it is the child or the teenager who is Net savvy and more likely to venture online to plan the family holiday on behalf of his parents. This lowers the chances of online monetary transactions. Credit cards purchases are still restricted to overseas deals with most people preferring cash and cheques for domestic travel.

You would be well advised to go with a reputed or known name, or at least one that comes with recommendations from other travellers. In a country of millions of PC/Net users, the Internet still remains a medium of research rather than a medium of transactions. But with so many worlds to explore within our world, a little risk may give us the experience of a life time. 

MITALI PAREKH

Info

13 per cent of the holiday searches are for travel packages

A Train of Thought

A more unlikely place to plan a holiday would be the Indian Railways official site at www.indianrail.gov.in. Not only is the site extensively and exhaustively stocked with information to show the availability of seats and track the progress of your ticket through the waiting list, you can also avail of some unique offers. For instance, the little known tourist trains can be a short vacation by themselves. The Royal Orient train and the Palace on Wheels are two luxuriant trails that give a taste of Indian opulence. A shorter route is taken by trains such as the Shivalik Deluxe Express, Shivalik Palace Train and the Shivalik Queen Train—each giving you an uninterrupted view of the Shivalik mountain range that lies at the feet of the Himalayas.



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